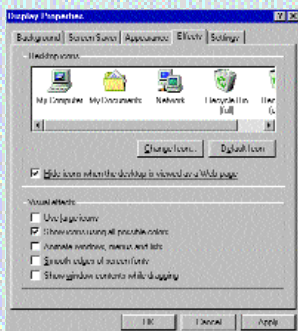


opening the properties for the printer. Changes made here will reflect in all applications, so change all settings to the most economical ones. You can change the settings back to higher quality as required from each application.

The wallpaper looks great, but these icons look patchy on it.

Icons on the desktop usually ruin the look of the wallpaper. The most obvious solution is to change the background colour of the desktop so that most of the icon labels may blend into the wallpaper. This can be done from **Control Panel > Desktop > Appearance**. However, getting the right colour is quite cumbersome and usually you will



Hide icons to get rid of patches from your desktop

not get uniformity across the entire screen. Another option is to hide the icons. In the Display Properties, under the Effects tab, enable 'Hide icons when the desktop is set as a Web page'. Thus, when the desktop is set as a Web page (using Active Desktop), no icons will be displayed. Yet

another way is to edit your system's registry and disable your desktop altogether. Go to **Start > Run** and type **regedit**. Navigate to the registry key **HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Policies\Explorer**. Here, create a new DWORD value called **NoDesktop**. Edit this value and change it to **1**. The next time you reboot Windows, your desktop icons will have disappeared! To undo this, simply delete the registry key you added. A better solution is to use software such as Iconoid (www.sillysot.com) to overcome the problem. This software can make icon backgrounds and labels transparent, so there will be no patches. It can also save and restore icon positions for different screen resolutions.

Sometimes the CDs that I write are not read by some CD-ROM drives and other players. This happens with various CDs—data, MP3, audio, etc.

Burning CDs is quite simple with the applications available today. It is largely Wizard driven—you just need to select what kind of CD you want to write and the source files and you're done. However, sometimes you will find that the CD-Rs are not read by all drives and players. This has to do with either the CD itself, or the way it is burnt. You may have noticed this behaviour more with CD-RWs than with CD-Rs. VCD players are more tolerant than most other players, but

they can be quirky too.

The first thing you should try is lowering the writing speed. Many older drives and players cannot read CDs burnt at high speeds. This is especially true with Audio CDs. With data CDs, if writing at lower speeds does not help, the CD-ROM drive's lens may require cleaning. Also, you may want to turn off real-time processing features in the CD writing application. Thus, when burning an Audio CD, use uncompressed WAV files for the source and use MPEG-1 video files for VCDs. This will not only reduce chances of errors when writing the CD, it will also decrease the odds of the burn process failing due to buffer underruns.

When burning MP3 CDs for an MP3 player, first convert all your MP3 files to one bit rate (96 or 128 Kbps) to ensure that none of them are encoded with very high, very low or variable bit rates. Although relatively new players can read these formats, many of the older ones cannot. They have minimum and maximum bit rate limits and some of them don't understand variable bit rates. If nothing works, you will have to change the kind of CD-Rs or CD-RWs you use for burning.

Three of us share the computer. How can we have different settings?

Different users on the same PC would like to have different settings for the desktop, the location where their files

are saved, separate e-mail settings, etc. Windows NT, 2000 and XP are already configured for multiple users and Windows 9x can be made to provide similar functionality. Different users on Windows 9x would have their own desktops, Start Menu items, themes, My Documents folders, History, Favourites, etc. Hence, each user can have his or her own profile and you won't have to change the settings every time you want to use the PC. The settings can be locked



Configure Windows to save multiple user profiles

by a password so that other users can't change them.

To set up multiple user profiles in Windows, open **Control Panel > Passwords > User Profiles**. Enable 'Users can customize their own preferences...'. When a new user logs on, a folder with that user's name will be created in **\Windows\Profiles** with all the personalised settings.

For multiple e-mail inboxes, you can set up multiple identities in Outlook Express. Each user's e-mail would be under his or her own identity, which can be protected by a password. You don't have to waste time sorting

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